Ethics of Artificial Intelligence

Course: *IDAI 700-02*
Semester: *Fall 2025*
Times: *Asynchronous*
Location: *Online*

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COURSE DESCRIPTION

This graduate course introduces students to foundational concepts and emerging ideas in the ethics of artificial intelligence. As an online, asynchronous course, it is designed to provide multiple pathways for learning and give students the flexibility they need to understand this material in the way that works best for them. The course is divided into nine units, and it also requires students to conduct independent research in AI ethics. For each unit, you'll find a Unit Overview document that lists what you should watch and read, and what assignments you'll need to complete and when they are due.

COURSE MATERIAL

Nearly everything you need for the course can be found on MyCourses: the Unit Overviews, my interviews with the authors you'll be reading, my lectures, my PowerPoint slides, and most the required readings. The only thing you'll need to buy, and I recommend doing so right away, is Hilke Schellmann's book *The Algorithm: How AI Decides Who Gets Hired, Monitored, Promoted, and Fired & Why We Need to Fight Back Now* (Hachette Book Group 2024, ISBN-13 9780306827341).

VALIDATING YOUR ID

Since this is an online course, RIT requires students to validate their IDs. To comply with policy, please send me an e-mail as soon as the course begins and list a few days/times that you are available for a brief meeting on Zoom. We need to have the meeting before 6 pm on Friday, September 5th. During the meeting, you'll need to bring a photo ID that I can compare with the one stored in SIS. Although RIT mandates the process to ensure grading integrity, I'm looking forward to this opportunity to get to know you and answer any questions you may have about the course.

MAIN LEARNING GOALS

- Introduce students to central topics in AI ethics, with some attention to AI policy.
- Familiarize students with the practice of making theoretical and applied claims about AI ethics, including arguments, that professionals will recognize as thoughtful and well-supported.
- Introduce students to the rigors of conducting independent, graduate-level AI ethics research.

OFFICE HOURS
There are many convenient ways for us to discuss the course. Please reach out via e-mail and let me know if you'd like to have a conversation there, on Zoom, or over the phone. I aim to reply within 36 hours (weekdays) and 48 hours (weekends and holidays). So, please plan accordingly.

GRADED ASSIGNMENTS

- *Quizzes are worth 30% of the final grade*. There are 11 open book quizzes, distributed across many of the units, and your lowest quiz grade will be automatically dropped. You will take the quizzes in the Quizzes section of MyCourses, and the due dates for each quiz are listed in the Unit Overviews. All Unit Overviews are on MyCourses.

- *Reflection Papers are worth 30% of the final grade*. There are 9 reflection papers, distributed across many of the units, and your lowest grade will be automatically dropped. The instructions for each one can be found in the Assignments section of MyCourses, and the due dates for each Reflection Paper are listed in the Unit Overviews. All Unit Overviews are on MyCourses.

- *Independent Research Paper is worth 40% of the final grade.* It has several components (research portfolio, collaborative engagement, and research paper) and all the specifics, including the due dates, can be found in the "Independent Research Paper" document on MyCourses.

GRADE VERIFICATION

- After each assignment, it is your responsibility to ensure that the correct grade is uploaded to MyCourses. If any mistakes arise, please bring them to my attention immediately so they can be rectified. It will not be permissible to revisit grades for past assignments at the end of the term.

GRADE SCHEME & FINAL GRADES

- 93.00-100 A
- 90-92 A-
- 87-89 B+
- 83-86 B
- 80.00-82 B-
- 77.00-79 C+
- 73.00-76 C
- 70.00-72 C-
- 60.00-69 D

- Final grades are not automatically rounded up. Borderline grades will be determined at the professor's discretion, considering factors such as the student's grades improving over the course of the term.

- Incomplete (I) grades will only be given for documented emergencies cleared by the Director of the AI program.

Academic Integrity and LLM Policy

- Academic integrity is a prerequisite for all RIT courses. Appropriate disciplinary measures— potentially including being given a failing grade for the course—will be taken if anyone is found cheating. Plagiarism, the act of presenting other people's (or machine-generated) writing or ideas as your own, will be considered cheating. Your rights and responsibilities as a member of Rochester Institute of Technology's academic community can be found here.

- The LLM policy for this class is straightforward. You are not allowed to use LLMs when taking quizzes or writing the Reflection Papers. However, you are required to use an LLM when conducting your Independent Research. That assignment has an AI Reflection Section, and the instructions specify exactly how you should use the tool and document your activity.

DISABILITIES

- RIT is committed to providing reasonable accommodations to students with disabilities. If you would like to request accommodations, please contact the Disability Services Office. It's located in the Student Alumni Union, Room 1150. For more information, go here.

EMERGENT CHANGES TO THE COURSE

Course requirements, assignment deadlines, readings, viewings, and grading procedures may need to be adjusted as the semester progresses. Any changes will be communicated via MyCourses and e-mail. You are responsible for regularly checking the e-mail address listed in MyCourses and staying informed about any updates.

IMPORTANT GENERAL DATES

- First Day of Class: August 25th
- Fall Break: October 13th - 14th
- Thanksgiving: November 26th – 28th
- Last Day of Class: December 8th

DUE DATES FOR UNITS

All assignments for Units #1 - #3 are due by the end of the day on Sunday, September 14th. The assignments are listed in the Unit Overviews on MyCourses.

Unit #1 AI & Ethics Fundamentals

This unit provides a foundation for thinking critically about AI and understanding the basic dimensions of ethical reasoning in the Western philosophical tradition.

Unit #2 AI Ethics Essentials
This unit provides a foundation for understanding AI ethics.

Unit #3 AI Ethics and Power
This unit provides a foundation for understanding how AI ethics issues are related to concerns about power.

All assignments for Units #4 - #5 are due by the end of the day on Sunday, October 5th. The assignments are listed in the Unit Overviews on MyCourses.

Unit #4 AI Ethics Skepticism
This unit covers the main reasons critics are skeptical about AI ethics.

Unit #5 AI Ethics and Bans
This unit examines the most extreme position in AI ethics: the complete prohibition of certain technologies. We will explore whether technology bans are ever justified or if they represent an overreach that stifles innovation and beneficial uses. To ground these abstract questions in concrete policy discussions, this unit focuses specifically on the ongoing debate about facial recognition technology.

All assignments for Unit #6 are due by the end of the day on Sunday, October 26th. The assignments are listed in the Unit Overview on MyCourses.

Unit #6 AI Ethics in Hiring and Work
This unit examines how AI is transforming hiring and workplace practices. This is an applied unit that brings AI ethics into practice through real-world case studies and investigative findings. By analyzing specific AI applications in recruitment and employee management, we will deepen our understanding of fundamental AI ethics issues that are relevant across many contexts and introduce the problem of dehumanization.

All assignments for Units #7-#9 are due on Sunday, December 7th. The assignments are listed in the Unit Overviews on MyCourses.

Unit #7 AI Ethics and Audits
This unit is an introduction to the emerging field of AI audits—what they are, why they matter, and the complex challenges involved in implementing them effectively. Through examining real-world examples and expert perspectives, students will gain insight into how auditing serves as a critical tool for responsible AI governance while recognizing its limitations and ongoing debates about best practices.

Unit #8 AI Ethics and Healthcare
This unit examines some of the ways that AI is transforming healthcare and the complex ethical challenges this transformation creates. By exploring issues of informed consent, the debate over

whether AI can achieve genuine empathy, and practical scenarios for using AI to improve medical communication, we will deepen our understanding of core AI ethics concepts.

Unit #9 AI Ethics and Human-Like Design

This unit explores the ethics of designing AI systems with human-like features, examines why these design choices matter, and critically evaluates various approaches to anthropomorphic design, including the precautionary approach.